

BRIGITTE BARDOT & THE NEW WAVE

Filming Freedom



1956. A former ballet student asks Rose Repetto for a shoe as soft as a slipper, strong enough for the street.



What Is on Your Feet

The ballet flat was invented for one woman

Because she could not walk on the cobblestones of a fishing village called Saint-Tropez.

Repetto calls the model Cendrillon — Cinderella. It has since sold in the millions.

Two revolutions, three years apart. One of the body. One of the camera. Tonight they collide.

A Journey Through Freedom and Its Price



Introduction to the Subject

Far more than a pout, a beach and a hairstyle.

Bardot is a way of reading the second half of the twentieth century: the collapse of the post-war moral order, the invention of youth, the birth of modern celebrity.

The journey.

From the bourgeois sixteenth arrondissement to a Mediterranean fishing village; from film sets to the ice floes of Labrador; from the covers of Elle to the courtrooms of Paris.

The promise.

A genuine revolutionary of the image — and a woman repeatedly convicted for inciting racial hatred. Both statements are true.

Holding both together — that is the intellectual work of this evening.

PART 1

THE MANUFACTURE OF AN ICON

How “BB” Was Built — and Who Held the Tools.



The Four Founding Dates

The arc of a life in four milestones.



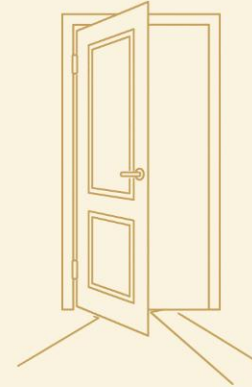
1934

Born into the Paris bourgeoisie,
28 September.



1956

And God Created Woman, Saint-
Tropez.



1973

The exit, at thirty-nine. She never
comes back.



2025

28 December, La Madrague,
aged ninety-one.

The arc does not end in triumph. It ends in argument — and that is the honest ending.

France in the 1950s



Setting the Scene: A Country Under a Lid

A rigid, Catholic, exhausted country.

The Fourth Republic falls every few months; the Church is powerful, the family sacred. Frenchwomen have had the vote only since 1944.

Under the lid, something is boiling.

The baby boom produces a mass of young people with time, money and no war to fight.

And America pours in.

Jazz, blue jeans, Coca-Cola, Brando, James Dean. The 1946 Blum–Byrnes agreement floods French screens with American films.

It needed only a face.

The Bourgeois Cage

1949

A family council allows the fourteen-year-old to model for Junior: no pay, no family name.

The initials

Born of bourgeois shame — a way of not printing “Bardot”.

B.B.

The result

Europe's most famous initials, created by censorship.

So the magazine printed her initials instead. B.B. — a brand invented by accident.



The Image Before the Actress

Elle, Vadim, and the Manufacture of a Face

Elle, 1949. Fourteen, photographed in profile, no make-up. The founding editor, Hélène Lazareff, is a friend of her mother's.

Roger Vadim. Met at an audition for a film never made. She is not yet fifteen; he is twenty-one.

Seventeen films before Saint-Tropez. Married December 1952. Light comedies, costume pictures, bit parts opposite Kirk Douglas and Dirk Bogarde.

A working actress with a decade of training and half a career behind her.



Dismantling the Legend — The Pygmalion Myth

The beautiful story. The svengali and his creature; the sculptor and the clay.

The facts do not support it. A cover star before him. A trained dancer before him.

What Vadim actually did. He found the frame. He filmed what was already there and added a scandal.

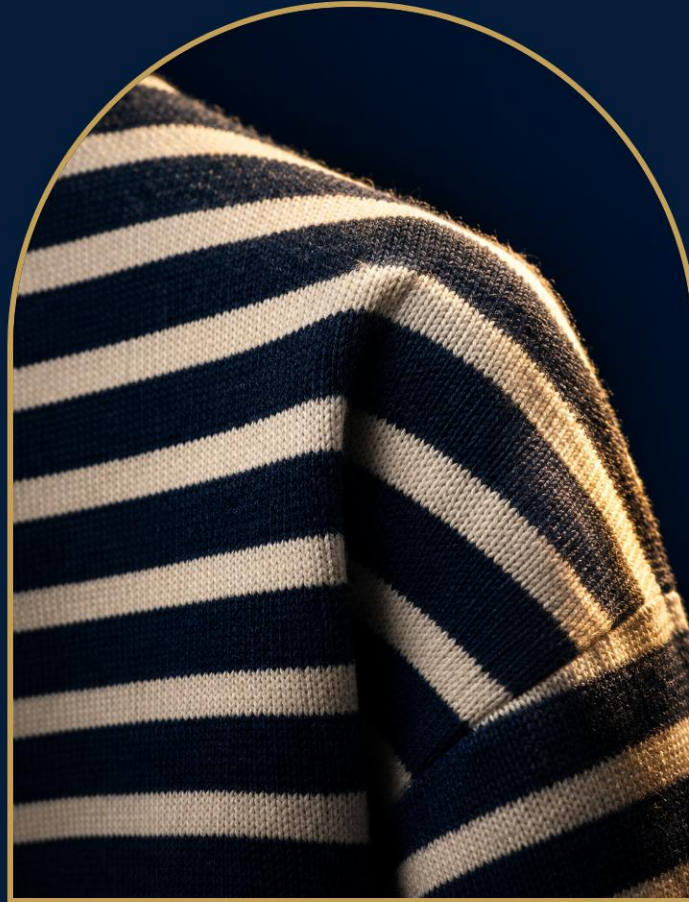
The myth says a man created a woman. The record says an entire industry did — and that she was fourteen when it started.

The Anti-Glamour

A Lasting Transformation — What Bardot Actually Changed

Glamour in 1955 is visible effort.

Hair set, waist boned, eyebrows drawn, gown as architecture.



Bardot looked as though she had just got out of bed.

Bare feet, the tousled choucroute, ballet flats, the Breton shirt, gingham, the bikini at eighteen.

Hollywood engineered its blondes. Bardot appeared not to have tried at all — the most influential piece of engineering of the decade.



1956: Saint-Tropez

A First Film, a Small Village, and a Character Without Guilt

The facts first. Autumn 1956. Vadim's first film, at twenty-eight. **Juliette feels no guilt whatsoever.** That is the entire scandal. Vadim removed the punishment and the shame — and filmed a barefoot mambo on a bar table that is still electric seventy years later. **The second legend, dismantled.** Signac, Matisse, Bonnard, Colette, Sartre, Gréco, Picasso, Sagan were there first.

The bomb did not go off in France. It went off somewhere else.

1957: The American Detonation

How a French Flop Became an American Earthquake

Condemned, cut — and unstoppable.

Distributed by Kingsley-International; condemned by the National Legion of Decency; in Philadelphia the DA threatens to seize the prints.

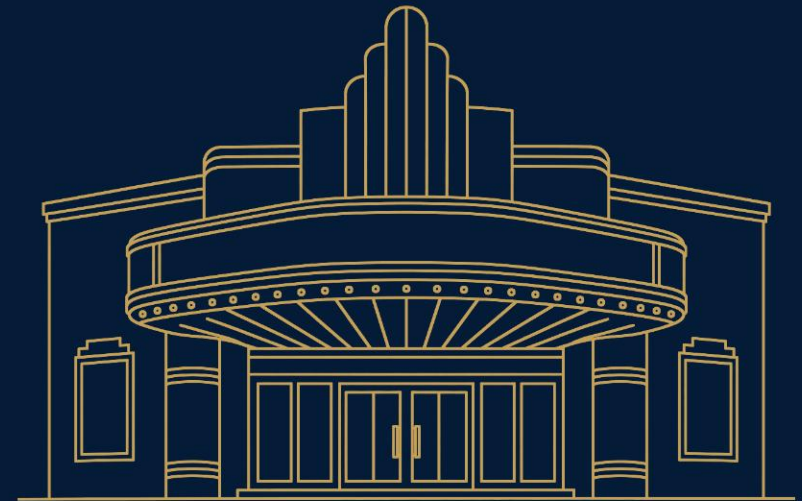
More than four million dollars.

An astonishing figure for a subtitled French picture in the 1950s — one of the most successful foreign films ever released in the United States.

The consequence that matters.

Peter Bogdanovich: this film broke French cinema out of the art house and into the mainstream.

Bardot did not make the New Wave. But she built its bridge to America.



PART 2

THE NEW WAVE

*A Revolution in the Grammar of Cinema — and
the Voice That Sang Beside It.*



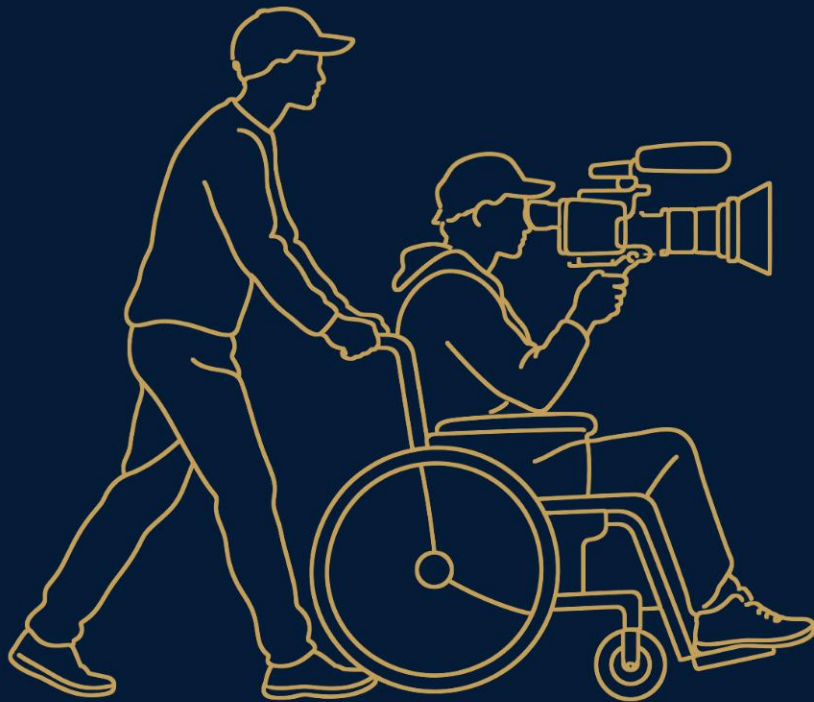
The Angry Young Critics

A Magazine, a Cinémathèque, and a Twenty-Two-Year-Old



A French revolution made by young men who worshipped American B-movies. The debt runs both ways.

Breathless, 1960



Twenty-Three Days, No Permits, and a Girl from Iowa

The method is the message.

No studio, no sets, no permits, no lighting rigs. Raoul Coutard pushed along the pavement in a wheelchair; dialogue called out and dubbed afterwards.

The accident that changed cinema.

The film ran too long. Godard removed pieces from the middle of shots.

Belmondo and Seberg.

He imitates Bogart in a shop window and becomes the model for every anti-hero of the next twenty years.

**The face of the French New Wave belonged to a girl from
Marshalltown, Iowa.**



Two Revolutions, One Wind

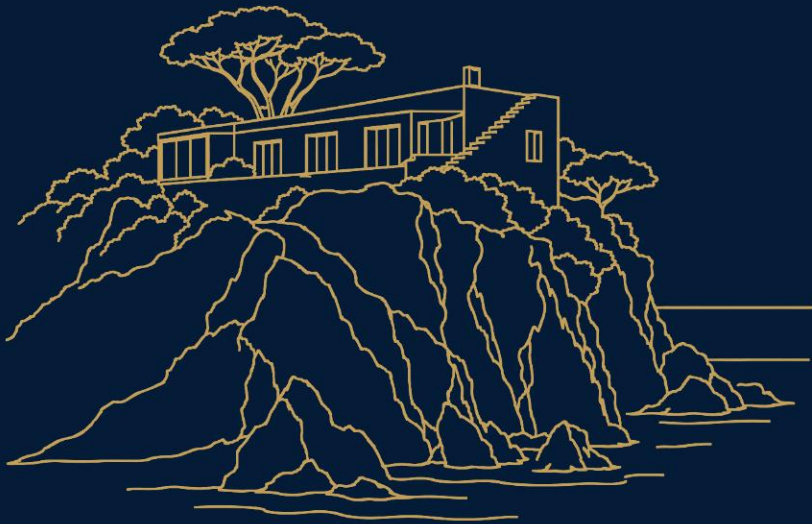
The half that is right. Not a New Wave actress in the technical sense: a career built inside the industrial French cinema; by the late 1950s the highest-paid actress in France.

The half that is false. Brigitte Bardot starred in one of the greatest films of the New Wave, directed by Jean-Luc Godard.

The deeper connection is timing. 1956: a woman on screen who does exactly what she wants and refuses to feel bad.

Bardot did not join the New Wave. She was its weather.

Contempt, 1963



When Godard Filmed Bardot Filming the Myth

Le Mépris.

Godard's most expensive film: Ponti and Levine producing; Piccoli, Jack Palance, Fritz Lang as himself.

The producers demanded a nude scene.

Godard shot a new opening: a woman asking, item by item, whether her husband likes her — under a red filter, then a blue one.

An interior life.

Black wig, Breton shirt, headband — a woman who is being looked at, knows it, and is quietly deciding she has had enough.

They asked for flesh. He delivered an indictment — and made them pay for it.

The Voice — Bardot and Gainsbourg

The Song That Was Locked in a Drawer for Nineteen Years

1967.

A disastrous first date — Gainsbourg loses the power of speech. She demands the most beautiful love song he can imagine.

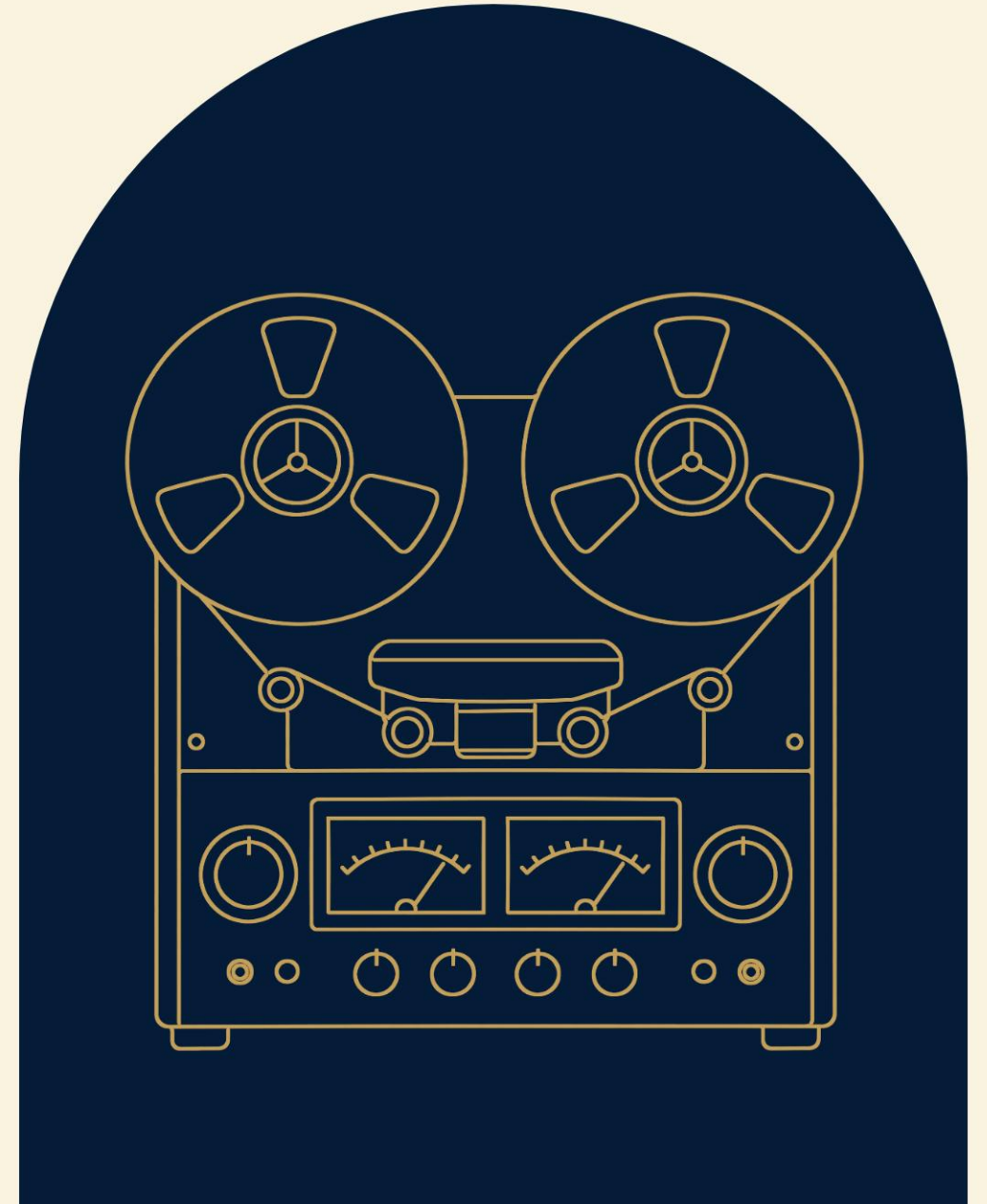
One glass booth, about two hours.

Word leaks; Gunter Sachs is incandescent; Bardot begs him not to release it. He puts the tape in a drawer.

1969, with Jane Birkin.

Banned across Europe, denounced by the Vatican, withdrawn by its own label — and the first foreign-language single ever to reach number one in Britain.

Birkin sings it as a girl. Bardot sings it as an equal.



The Wave Crosses the Atlantic



From the Champs-Élysées to New Hollywood

Bonnie and Clyde, 1967.

Newman and Benton, obsessed with *Breathless*, offer their script to Truffaut, then Godard. Arthur Penn makes it.

After it comes everything.

Badlands, *Mean Streets*, *The Godfather*, *Taxi Driver*. Scorsese, Coppola, Spielberg, Lucas, Stone.

The coda.

Vadim goes to Hollywood — *Barbarella* (1968), an English remake of *And God Created Woman*. Neither works.

Their cinema is the child of the French New Wave — which was the child of their cinema.

PART 3

THE MYTH AND THE SHADOW

*The Price of the Image, and an Honest
Reckoning.*



An Honest Portrait Cannot End in Celebration

- 1 What the image cost the woman who carried it.
- 2 What she did with the fifty years she had left after she walked away.
- 3 The shadow — the reason her own country could not agree on how to bury her.

Without idealisation, and without a verdict she is no longer here to answer.

Beauvoir's Verdict — and the Cost of the Image



Esquire, August 1959

Brigitte Bardot and the Lolita Syndrome.

The most formidable intellect in France makes her argument about French womanhood in an American men's magazine, in English.

A subject who takes.

Bardot refuses the apparatus of seduction. She does not perform desire; she has desires and acts on them.

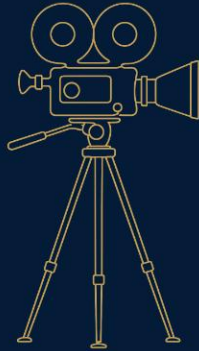
A freedom with an expiry date.

A second suicide attempt at twenty-six. The most photographed woman on earth, living it as a siege. A son, born 1960, raised largely by others.

"I can understand hunted animals, because of the way I was treated." — Brigitte Bardot, to the Associated Press

1973 — The Exit and the Cause

Forty-Seven Films, Then Silence



Before 1973

Forty-seven films in seventeen years. The most photographed woman in the world.



After 1973

The Fondation Brigitte Bardot, 1986. The seals, the 1987 auction, the animals before the humans.

She gave away the objects of her fame to fund the work of her afterlife.



The Cost of the Seal Campaign

It devastated Inuit communities across the Canadian Arctic.



The Convictions

Convicted by French courts five times between 1997 and 2021 for inciting racial hatred.



The Paradox Itself

Not “the art is separate from the artist”.

The legend does not erase the record. The record does not erase the work. The task is to carry all of it.

28 December 2025

A Funeral That Divided a Country

La Madrague, aged ninety-one.

Her house above the sea at Saint-Tropez, for more than half a century. Two operations for cancer; conscious, and concerned about animals, to the end.

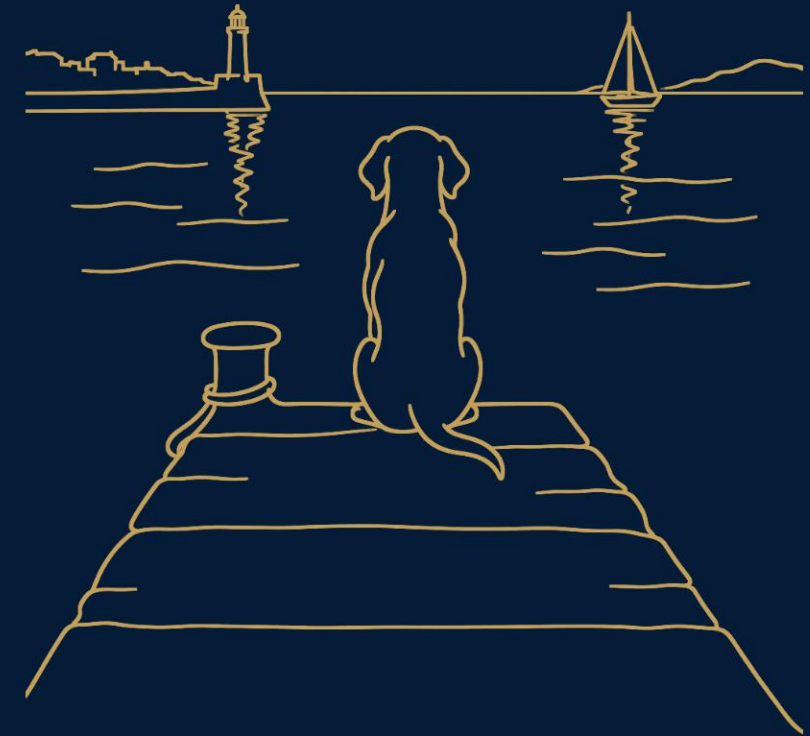
7 January 2026.

A wicker coffin carried by the son from whom she had been estranged. Hundreds watching on a giant screen on the port, many holding their dogs.

The marine cemetery of Saint-Tropez.

Beside her parents and grandparents — and a short walk from the grave of Roger Vadim.

A country that could not agree on how to bury her — the most accurate summary of Brigitte Bardot anyone has produced.



What the Wave Left Behind



A Living Legacy

The first revolution is on your feet.

The flat shoe, the striped shirt, the bared shoulder, the hair that is meant to look as though nobody arranged it.

The second is in your pocket.

Shot on the street, without permission. Available light. A camera you hold in one hand.

Now describe how a video is made on a telephone in 2026.

The grammar Godard invented in twenty-three days in 1959 is the native language of the most widely used medium on earth.

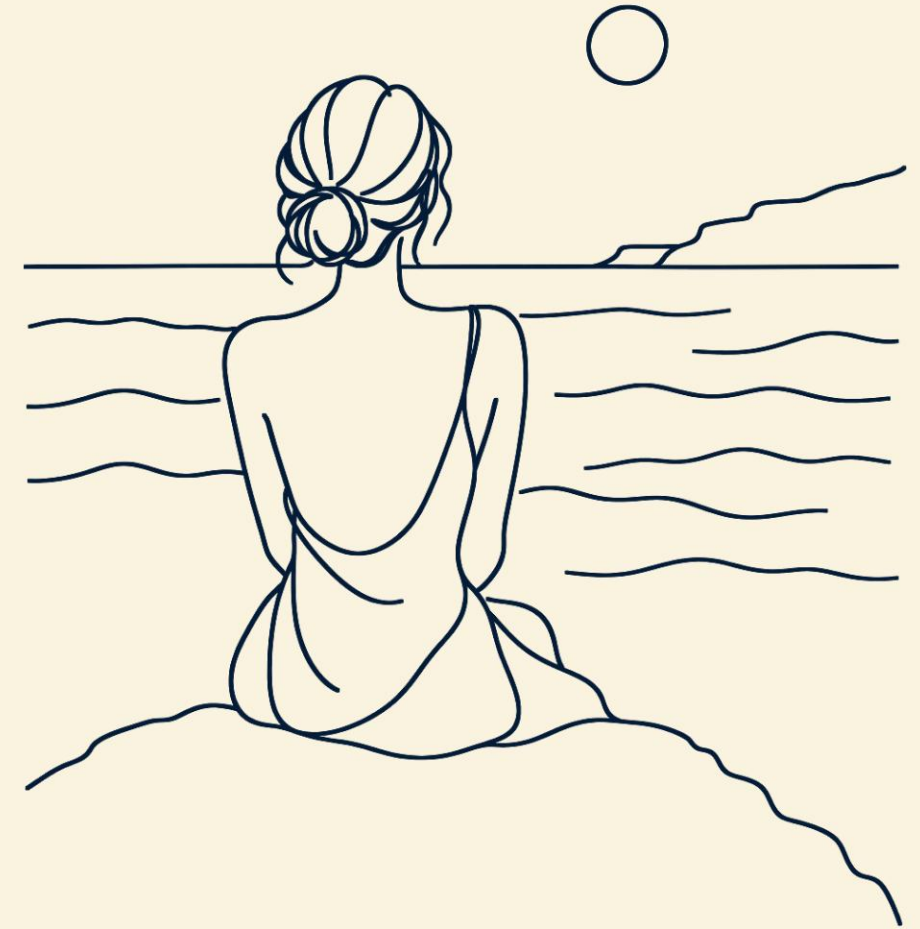
Seventy Years in One Hour

She took the shame out of the female body on film. She made ease more powerful than effort.

She carried French cinema into the American mainstream and opened the door through which the New Wave walked.

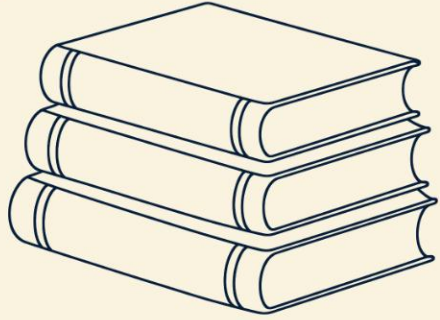
She gave away the objects of her fame and spent fifty-two years on behalf of creatures who could not thank her.

And she said things, repeatedly and for decades, for which the courts of her own country repeatedly convicted her.



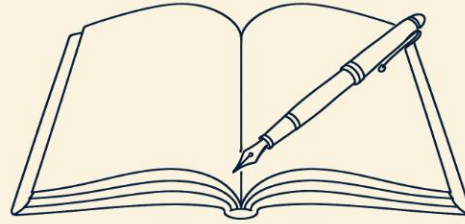
The one thing she consistently refused, from fourteen to ninety-one, was to be told what she ought to be.

Sources & Further Reading



Reading

Simone de Beauvoir, Brigitte Bardot and the Lolita Syndrome (Esquire, 1959) · Ginette Vincendeau, Brigitte Bardot (BFI Film Stars) · Brigitte Bardot, Initiales B.B. (1996) · Richard Neupert, A History of the French New Wave Cinema.



The Founding Text

François Truffaut, "Une certaine tendance du cinéma français", Cahiers du cinéma no. 31, January 1954.



Films, in Order

Le Mépris / Contempt (Godard, 1963) · À bout de souffle / Breathless (Godard, 1960) · Et Dieu... créa la femme (Vadim, 1956) · La Vérité (Clouzot, 1960) · Viva Maria! (Malle, 1965) · Nouvelle Vague (Linklater, 2025).